



SUSTAINABLE SUMMER TIPS

Water-wise gardening and mulch mastery: smart strategies for a thriving summer landscape.

Smart summer watering.

- Water deeply, less often – encourages deep root growth.
- Early morning is best – reduces evaporation and fungal risk.
- Target the base – avoid wetting foliage to reduce fungal disease.
- Mulch after watering – to lock in moisture.

Drip irrigation and soaker hoses.

- Deliver water right to the root zone (right were the plants need it!)
- Minimize runoff and evaporation
- Ideal for garden beds, veggie rows, and borders

Tip: use a timer for consistency—set it and forget it!



How to water deeply.

Encourage strong, drought-resistant roots by soaking the soil—not just the surface.

- Water slowly at the base of the plant.
- Aim to flood the root zone so water penetrates 6-8" deep—use a trowel or soil probe to check.
- Use a soaker hose or let a hose trickle for 15-30 minutes in each area.
- Fewer deep waterings are better than frequent shallow ones.

Tip: water until the soil feels moist about a hand's depth down—this supports deep root growth and stress resilience.



Mulch mastery.

More than just a finishing touch—mulch is a moisture-saving workhorse.

Mulch materials compared:

Material	Best use	Notes
Shredded bark	Beds, borders, trees	Long-lasting, suppresses weeds, and retains moisture
Straw	Veggie gardens	Light, good for soft fruit crops
Leaf compost	Around veggies and perennials	Feeds soil, improves structure, and returns organic matter to the earth
Pine straw	Around acid-loving plants	Lightweight, lets water through easily, and acidifies the soil
Stone	Dry/heat tolerant areas	Doesn't break down, reflects heat

Tip: keep mulch 2-3" deep and a few inches away from plant stems/trunks.

Homestead picks: water-wise winners

- Espoma® Organic Mulch and Compost
- Soaker hoses and irrigation timers
- Rain barrels



Drought-tolerant favorites.

Tough, beautiful, and wildlife-friendly.

- Black-eyed Susan; *Rudbeckia fulgida*
- Bear grass; *Eryngium yuccifolium*
- Blazing star; *Liatris spicata*
- Threadleaf Coreopsis; *Coreopsis verticillata*
- Wood sage/meadow sage; *Salvia nemorosa*
- Purple coneflower; *Echinacea purpurea*

